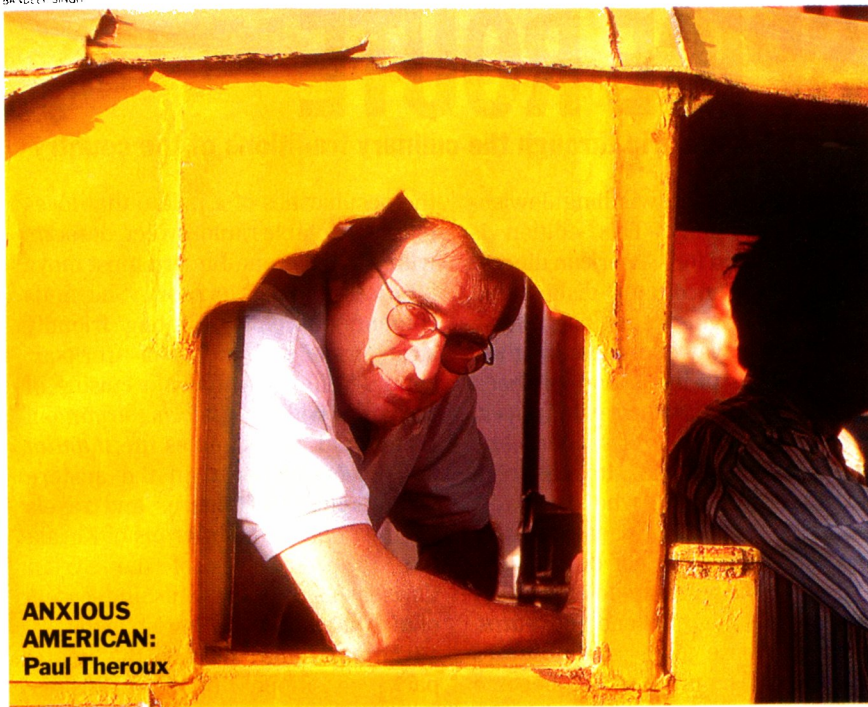
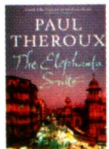




**ANXIOUS
AMERICAN:**
Paul Theroux

INDIAN EPIPHANY

Theroux is at his best as he returns to the India of economic miracle and spiritual retreats in this book of three novellas



THE ELEPHANTA SUITE

by PAUL THEROUX
Hamish Hamilton

Price: £4.50
Pages: 288

■ By Geeta Doctor

In an earlier time, a more gentler age, there was something endearing about Paul Theroux's American racketing his way through the Indian sub-continent on the railways of the Raj. There was still an element of romance, a vestige of grace that made the journey something of a discovery, even

in those small moments of misunderstanding as babu India tried to forge a link with the young Theroux as a traveller at large. Mostly, perhaps it was that we cared about what he registered of what was clearly an alien culture.

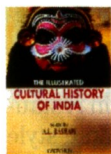
Theroux returns to India in the guise of the anxious American engaging with the new India. It is the incredible India of spiritual retreats in the foothills of the Himalayas, or the arid isolation of a famous godman and miracle-worker at the periphery of the electronic city of Bangalore, with its own reputation as an economic miracle; and the Mumbai that powers dreams of upwardly mobile as-

cents. Theroux engages the Asian elephant in its economic avatar, attended by the mahouts of eternal India, and comes through with tiny whiplashes of such ironic power that leave one completely breathless. The only difference now is that we don't care anymore what a Paul Theroux might think. The Elephant will amble through regardless and that is what makes the collection of tripartite views of the new India even more frightening.

Theroux takes on both the spirituality and the newfound material wealth of his Indian friends, framing them in the wisdom of the sages, who proclaim that everything will pass, eventually. His great triumph is to linger in the antechamber of that 'eventually' and document, with his customary vituperative eye, the freak show that passes for life in that interregnum of Indian existence. He cons the reader by making his American protagonists lumbering, inept and innocent. The Indian experience that his businessman and young woman seek is as brutal as the headlines that report a death by riot, or a roadside rape by a friendly acquaintance that might lead you to accept it as routine.

He gives these three lightly interlinked short stories a far more lurid conclusion than their passive beginnings might suggest. Sir Vidya Naipaul, his old mentor, would not approve of such desperate measures. Yet, as one of his more compassionate Indians explaining the *Diamond Sutra* to an American intones, "Words cannot express the truth." Theroux has found both the words and the images that create the most pitiless record of the poverty of our daily life, and as ever with him, the stench of deception that is at the heart of the Indian experience. It is Theroux at his best. ■

NEW RELEASES

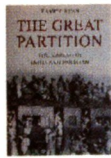


THE ILLUSTRATED CULTURAL HISTORY OF INDIA

Edited by A.L. BASHAM
Oxford

Price: Rs 345; Pages: 300

Adapted from *A Cultural History of India*, the new reader-friendly version traces literature, architecture, religion, music and other arts through three periods—ancient heritage, Muslim dominance and Western colonisation.



THE GREAT PARTITION: THE MAKING OF INDIA AND PAKISTAN

by YASMIN KHAN
Penguin

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The scholarly account of the greatest divisive catastrophe in modern history describes in mind-numbing detail the laceration of the subcontinent, the problem of rehabilitation and the scars of communal riots.



THE LAST THOUSAND DAYS OF THE BRITISH EMPIRE

by PETER CLARKE
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This is a history of the Empire in four parts, from the rise of imperialism to the end of the Second World War, when Great Britain, which controlled a quarter of the world's territory, faced liquidation.